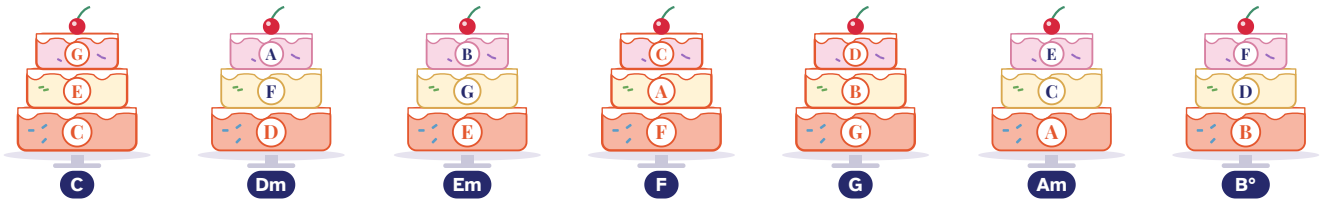
PART IV · CHORDS · 3

Chords in a key
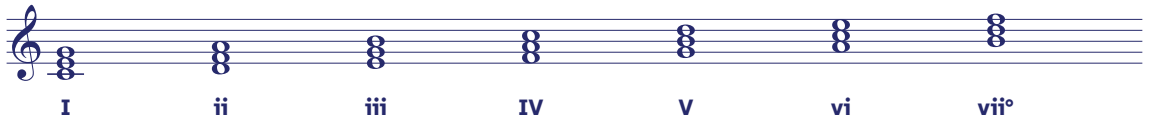
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

THE SECRET

Build a cake on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.



One cake on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work



The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 91.

NUMERAL	NAME	KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	IN C	IN G
I	tonic	major	3 + 2	C	G
ii	supertonic	minor	2 + 3	Dm	Am
iii	mediant	minor	2 + 3	Em	Bm
IV	subdominant	major	3 + 2	F	C
V	dominant	major	3 + 2	G	D
vi	submediant	minor	2 + 3	Am	Em
vii°	leading note	diminished	2 + 2	B°	F♯°

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

The three primary chords
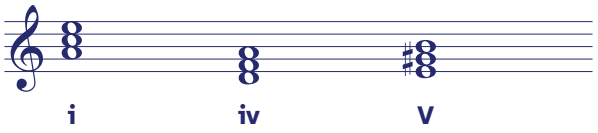
I, IV and V are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

THINK OF IT I is the key's own chord. IV and V are its two big neighbours. Between the three of them, every note of the scale has a chord to sit in.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

In a minor key

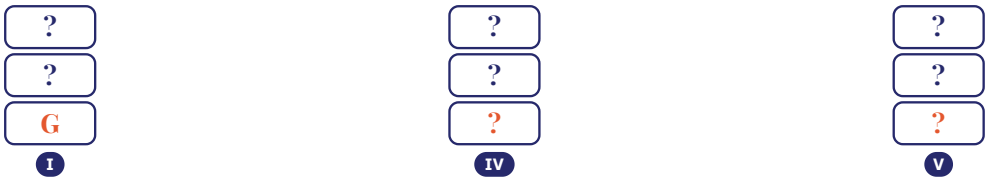
In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th** of the harmonic minor (p. 73), G♯. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.



A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

EXAMPLE 1

Find I, IV and V in G major



1. **Count up the scale** from G: which notes are 1st, 4th and 5th?
2. **Build a cake on each,** using the key signature (one sharp: F♯).
3. **Check the keys between:** are all three 3 + 2?

In G major: **I = G** (G B D), **IV = C** (C E G), **V = D** (D F♯ A), all major.

GAME

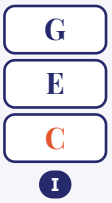
Which numeral?



All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



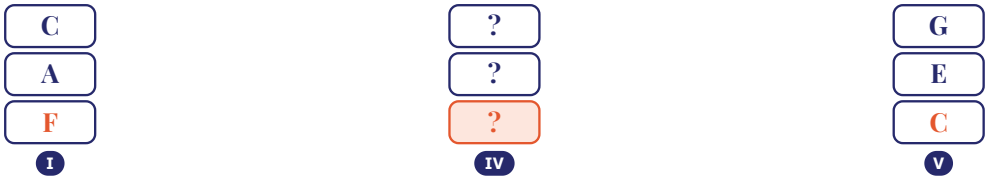
Left hand: C, F, G.

Play the cakes of I, IV and V in C major, then sing any nursery tune over them: these three fit almost every note.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find IV in F major



1. **Count up the scale** from F to the 4th note. Watch the key signature: one flat.
2. **Build the cake** on that note.
3. **Check the keys between.**

IV in F major is **B♭**: B♭ D F, 3 + 2, major.

EXAMPLE 3

Find V in D minor



1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A: build A C E.
2. **The 7th note** of the D minor scale is C. In the harmonic minor it is raised: to what?
3. **Put it in the middle layer.** What kind is the chord now?

C becomes **C♯**: V in D minor is A C♯ E, **A major**.

EXAMPLE 4

The chord on note 6 of C major



1. **Build the cake on A:** skip one, take the next, twice.
2. **Count the keys between:** major or minor?
3. **Note 6 of the scale:** which numeral, capital or small?

A C E, 2 + 3: **A minor**, numeral **vi** (small, because it is minor).

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 90 · Major scales p. 70 · Inversions p. 96

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords